

going on, but I figured it can't be good. My immediate response was to start selling futures.

Was the market selling off at the time?

Not at that point. I don't know if you remember, but the market was very strong going into 9/11. The crash hadn't hit the news yet. Then when the initial story came across the tape, it said that a small plane had hit the World Trade Center. The market actually went up. At the time, I had no idea what was really going on, but I thought it was ridiculous that the market was rallying, so I sold more.

The market went up after the news first came out?

Yes, go look at the chart. All of a sudden, the second plane hit the World Trade Center. The stock market hadn't opened yet, but the futures were trading. The market started dropping hard. I had the broker on the phone, and I told him, "I don't know what's going on, but I'm leaving and going to pick up my kids at school. Just sell me out of everything."

Why were you leaving?

I just wanted to get my kids. They were showing the planes hitting in New York and Washington.

But you were in Florida. What were they going to do—take out Palm Beach?

I agree. But what was going on was crazy, and I just wanted to be with my family.

Why did you liquidate your position before you left?

I didn't want to capitalize on people's misfortune. I felt weird having that short position. I still made a large profit on the day trade, but I left most of the money on the table relative to where the market traded when it reopened the following week. When the market reopened, I decided to be Mr. Patriotic. At the same time everyone else was selling, I was buying stocks and futures. Very quickly, I lost all the profit I had made on the 9/11 trades and then some.

You said that 9/11 was a major learning experience. In what way?